

Passing Analysis Report

Nigeria vs Côte d'Ivoire

AFCON 2023 Final · 11 February 2024
Competition Data: StatsBomb Open Data

Analysis Focus

Jean Michaël Seri — Player Pass Map
Côte d'Ivoire — Team Passing Network

Match ID: 3923881 | Competition ID: 1267 | Season ID: 107

1. Introduction

Event-level football data has become a central tool in modern performance analysis. Every touch, pass, and movement recorded during a match can be reconstructed into a **spatial and tactical narrative** of how a team and its individual players behaved in possession. Passing data in particular offers one of the richest signals available: it captures not just **who** played the ball, but **where, to whom**, and with what degree of **success**.

Analysing this data allows us to move beyond simple statistics and toward a genuine understanding of **player roles, team structure, and tactical behaviour**. A player's pass map can reveal whether they operate as a deep-lying distributor or an advanced creator, while a team's passing network can expose the underlying shape, balance, and dominant channels of progression that a team relies on in possession.

The purpose of this report is to apply both forms of analysis to a single high-profile fixture: the **AFCON 2023 Final** between Nigeria and Côte d'Ivoire. The analysis is presented in two parts:

- an **individual analysis** of Jean Michaël Seri's passing activity, presented as a pass map; and
- a **team analysis** of Côte d'Ivoire's passing network, presented as a node-and-edge diagram of player connections.

Both analyses are built using **StatsBomb open data**, accessed through the **Sbopen** parser and **statsbombpy** libraries, with all visualisations produced using **mplsoccer**, a Python library purpose-built for football pitch graphics.

2. Part 1 – Player Pass Map

2.1 Data and Method

For Part 1, the following match and player were selected:

- **Match:** Nigeria vs Côte d'Ivoire
- **match_id:** 3923881
- **competition_id:** 1267
- **season_id:** 107
- **Player:** Jean Michaël Seri (Côte d'Ivoire)

Match events were loaded using **Sbopen**. From the full event dataframe, pass events attributable to Seri were isolated by filtering on:

- `type_name == "Pass"`
- `player_name == "Jean Michaël Seri"`

Passes were then separated into two categories based on StatsBomb's `outcome_name` field:

- **Completed passes:** `outcome_name` is null
- **Incomplete passes:** `outcome_name` is not null

Start and end coordinates for each pass were taken directly from the `x`, `y`, `end_x`, and `end_y` fields.

The visualisation was constructed using `mplsoccer.Pitch` with the **StatsBomb** pitch type, drawn on a **dark green background** for visual contrast. **Completed passes** were plotted as **green arrows**, **incomplete passes** as **red arrows**, with a legend included to distinguish the two categories.

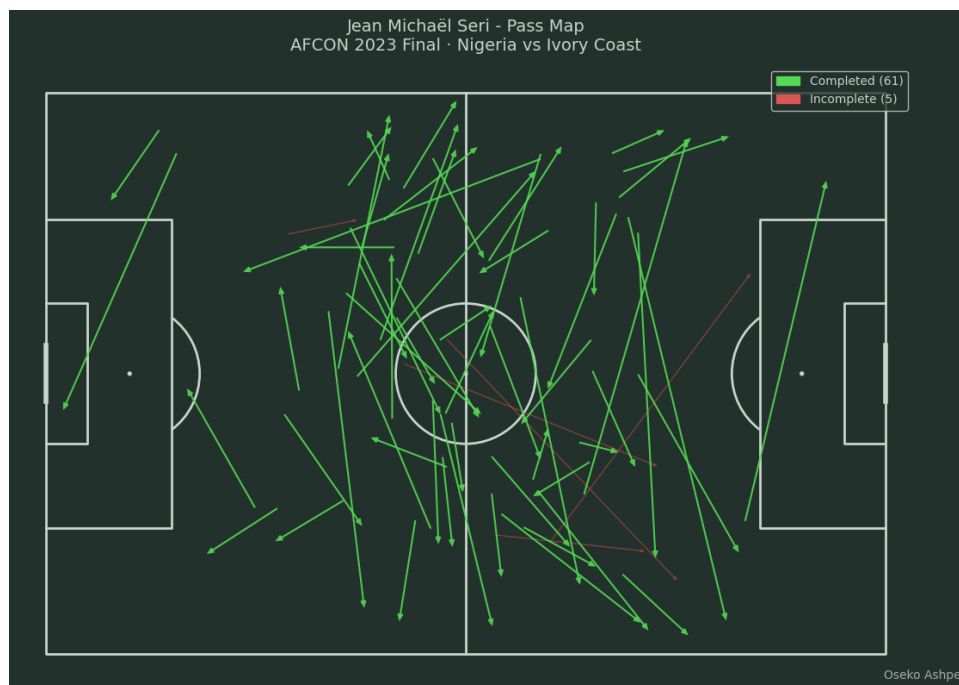


Figure 1: Jean Michaël Seri passing activity during Nigeria vs Côte d'Ivoire.

2.2 Result and Interpretation

Figure 1 shows the complete pass map for Jean Michaël Seri across the match. The visualisation provides a clear picture of his **receiving and passing zones**, his **positional role**, and the balance between safe and progressive passing.

- **Positioning:** The majority of Seri's passes originate from deeper central zones, around and just ahead of the centre circle, rather than from advanced areas. This confirms a **deep midfield** role rather than an attacking one.

- **Passing balance:** The map shows a clear mix of shorter circulation passes near the centre and longer diagonal balls out to the flanks, reflecting a balance between maintaining **possession control** and executing **progressive switches of play**.
- **Incomplete passes:** The small number of incomplete passes (shown in red) tend to correspond to the more **ambitious, line-breaking attempts**, generally longer or more progressive passes where a degree of risk is an acceptable trade-off for attacking value.
- **Role:** Taken together, the pattern is consistent with a **deep-lying playmaker**, a player positioned to receive frequently, retain possession reliably, and connect the defensive and attacking phases of play.

Metric	Value
Total passes attempted	66
Completed passes	61
Incomplete passes	5
Pass completion rate	≈ 92%

Seri attempted **66 passes** during the match, completing **61** and registering only **5** incomplete attempts, a completion rate of approximately **92%**. This combination of **high volume** and **high accuracy** indicates strong involvement in Côte d'Ivoire's build-up play, reliability when in possession, and a consistent ability to **connect defence and attack** throughout the final.

3. Part 2 – Team Passing Network

3.1 Data and Method

For Part 2, the analysis shifted from an individual player to the team level, with **Côte d'Ivoire** analysed as a whole. Event data was collected using a combination of **Sbopen** (for competition, match, and lineup data) and **statsbombpy** (for the event-level pass data).

The event dataframe was filtered to retain only actions where:

- `type == "Pass"`
- `team == "Côte d'Ivoire"`
- the pass was **completed**
- the pass was made in **open play** only (set pieces excluded)

The dataset was further restricted to passes occurring **before the first substitution**, ensuring the resulting network reflected Côte d'Ivoire's **original starting structure** rather than being influenced by changes made later in the match.

Player Nodes

For each player, a node was constructed using:

- the player's **average pass location** (x, y), used as the node's position on the pitch; and
- the player's **total number of passes made**, used to scale node size.

Each player's on-ball position was derived from StatsBomb's `position_id` field, mapped to a standard football position abbreviation (e.g. GK, LB, LCB, CDM, LCM, ST). These abbreviations were displayed **inside each node**, with the player's **surname** placed directly beneath.

Passing Links

Passing links (edges) were constructed by grouping completed passes by **passer and receiver** and counting the number of completed passes exchanged between each pair. To reduce visual clutter and isolate **stable, recurring relationships**, only connections with **at least four completed passes** were retained in the network.

Visualisation

The network was plotted on a dark green **StatsBomb** pitch using `mplsoccer.Pitch`, with the following encoding:

- **Nodes:** orange, sized in proportion to the number of passes made by each player
- **Links:** green, with thickness scaled to the number of passes exchanged between the connected players

- A **legend** included to clarify the meaning of node size and link thickness

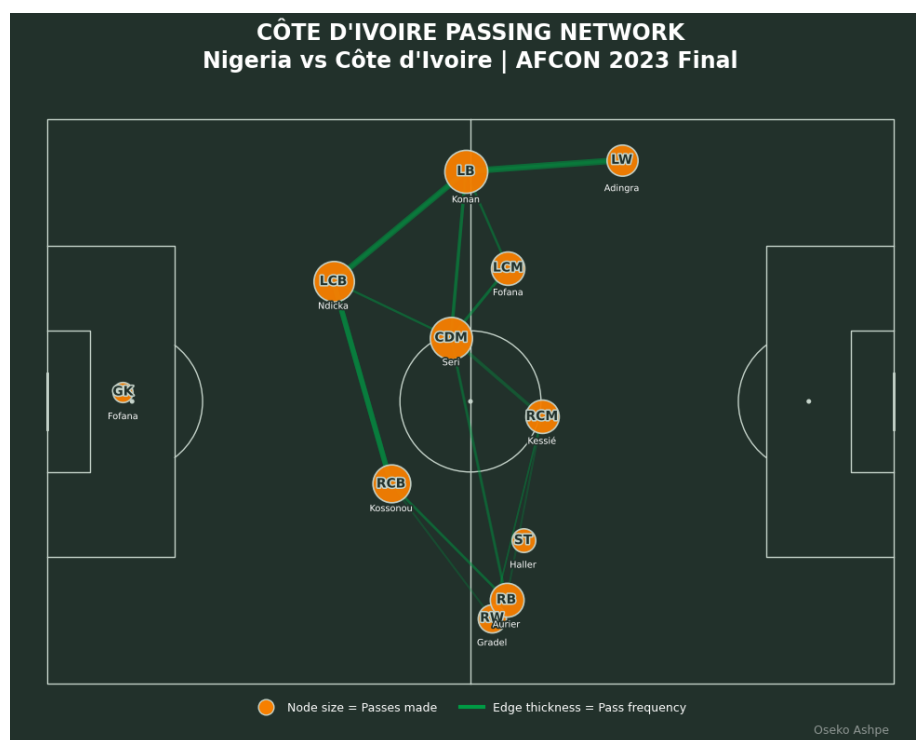


Figure 2: Côte d'Ivoire open-play passing network before the first substitution.

3.2 Result and Interpretation

Left-Side and Central Build-Up

The network shows the heaviest passing activity running through the **left side and centre** of the pitch, particularly through **Konan (LB)**, **Ndicka (LCB)**, **Kossonou (RCB)**, and **Seri (CDM)**. The single strongest connection in the entire network is **Konan to Adingra (18 completed passes)**, showing a direct and heavily used outlet from left-back to left winger. Immediately behind this, **Ndicka's connections to Konan (17) and Kossonou (15)** form the backbone of the defensive line's circulation, with Kossonou returning the ball to Ndicka a further 14 times. Together, these links show that a substantial proportion of Côte d'Ivoire's circulation in this match flowed along the **back line and up the left flank**, underlining the importance of left-sided defensive circulation to the team's build-up structure.

Seri as the Central Pivot

Seri (CDM) sits at the structural centre of the network, with passing connections extending toward **multiple areas of the pitch**, including both flanks of midfield. This central positioning reinforces his role as Côte d'Ivoire's primary **deep-lying playmaker**, consistent with the individual passing profile identified in Part 1, and confirms his function as the team's main link between defence and attack.

Right-Side Involvement

By contrast, **Aurier (RB)** and **Gradel (RW)** show notably smaller nodes and weaker connections, clustered toward the bottom of the network. This suggests **reduced reliance on the right flank** during the period of the match captured here, with the right side functioning more as an isolated outlet than a core passing channel.

Taken as a whole, the passing network points to a **left-focused, centrally organised possession structure**. Côte d'Ivoire's build-up in this match relied heavily on the connections between **Seri, Ndicka, and Konan**, while the right side played a comparatively minor role in progressing the ball.

4. Conclusion

This report has examined Côte d'Ivoire's passing performance in the AFCON 2023 Final through two complementary lenses: an **individual pass map** for Jean Michaël Seri, and a **team passing network** for Côte d'Ivoire as a whole.

At the individual level, Seri emerged as one of the key **possession organiser** for Côte d'Ivoire, combining a **high passing volume** (66 attempts) with **strong accuracy** (92% completion). His positioning and distribution pattern were consistent with a deep-lying playmaker, capable of retaining possession reliably while still contributing progressive passes.

At the team level, the passing network confirmed and extended this picture, revealing a **left-leaning, centrally structured** approach to possession. Côte d'Ivoire's build-up relied heavily on the connections between Ndicka, Konan, and Seri, with the right flank playing a comparatively limited role in the team's passing structure during the period analysed.

Together, these analyses demonstrate how raw **event-level football data**, once filtered, structured, and visualised, can be converted into **meaningful tactical insight**, offering a clear, evidence-based picture of both individual player roles and overall team behaviour in possession.